

Week Ahead

Friday, 27 March 2026

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Key inflation and labour market data

Plenty of data in the US and the Euro area to keep an eye on next week. In the US, the labour market is in focus, with NFP as the main event. In Europe, we are keeping an eye on flash estimates for inflation. The data will include the impact of higher energy prices as a result of the conflict in the Middle East and the closed Strait of Hormuz. In Sweden and Norway, the calendars are thinner and the markets are closed at the end of the week when Easter is just around the corner.

- US:** March employment (NFP) will be important for the Fed, after a volatile start to the year. Slow growth in both the demand for workers and the labour force has kept the labour market in a fragile balance during the past six months and has led the Fed to focus more on changes in the unemployment rate. Surveys (ISM manufacturing and consumer confidence) are likely to be impacted by the conflict in the Middle East. Supply side measures (delivery times) and price indices will be in focus for businesses.
- Euro area:** Consumption has been weak, and although not fully reflected in the February data there is a risk that the war in the Middle East will make households more cautious going forward. The first estimates for country specific as well as euro area flash HICP (March) will be released with the initial impact of higher energy prices being visible. Finally, next week will be the starting period for industrial production (Feb) with France on Friday.
- Sweden:** Retail sales and manufacturing PMI are the only data this week. The Riksbank's Jansson and Thedéen will speak on Tuesday. Markets close early on Thursday and are closed on Friday ahead of Easter.
- Norway:** Very thin data calendar and domestic market activity is expected to be muted as it is a short trading week due to Easter. Norges Bank will announce its daily NOK purchases for April on Wednesday. The surge in energy prices will boost petroleum taxes and equally reduce the need for Norges Bank's NOK purchases. However, these flows are smoothed, lagging and dependent on input from the MoF. Hence, we do not expect any large changes to the daily NOK purchases in April.

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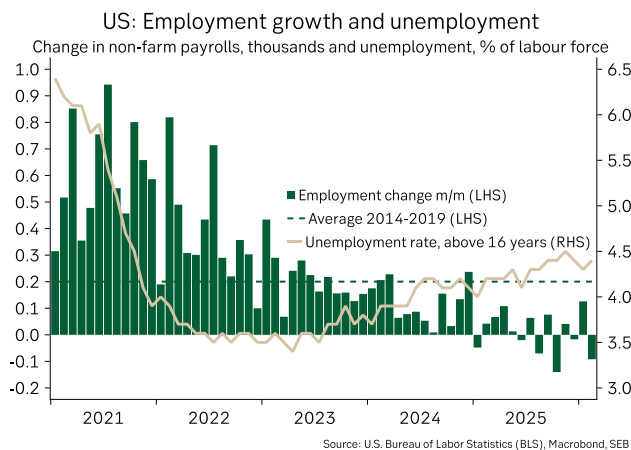
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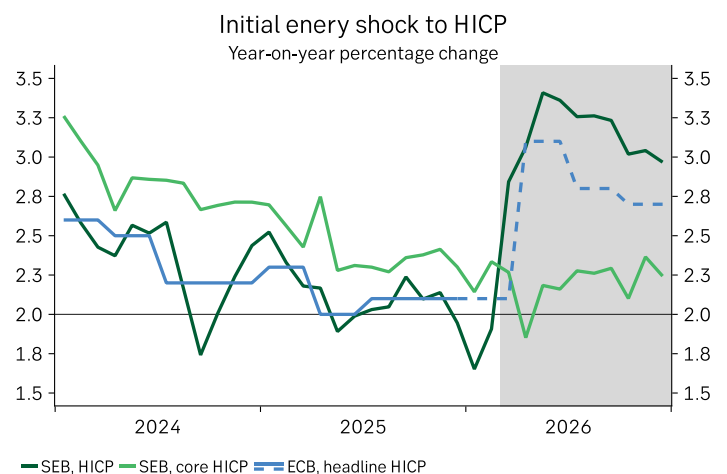
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Important labour market data for the Federal Reserve



Impact of higher energy prices in inflation data in the Euro area



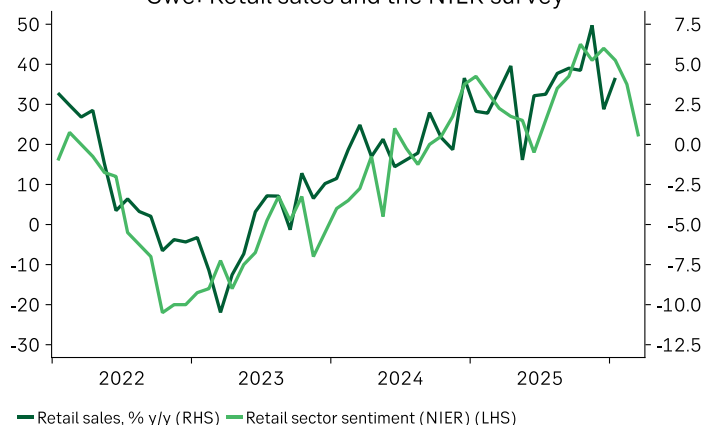
SWE: Retail sales (Feb)

Monday 30, 08:00

% mm/yy	SEB	Cons.	Prev.
Retail sales	0.4/4.4	---	0.1/4.1

- A decline in December interrupted the acceleration seen in retail sales since the middle of last year, but sales rebounded somewhat in January.
- Retail sentiment and expected sales volumes increased to cyclical highs in 2025 but turned markedly lower in March. This highlights downside risks to retail sales and household consumption from the Iran war.
- The impact in February should, however, be small and we predict retail sales to have increased largely in line with the underlying trend.

Swe: Retail sales and the NIER survey



Source: Statistics Sweden (SCB), Swedish National Institute of Economic Research (Konjunkturinstitutet, NIER), Macrobond, SEB

GER/FRA: Retail sales (Feb)

Tuesday 31, 8.00 and 8:45

% mom / yoy	SEB	Cons.	Prev.
Germany	--	0.4/1.0	-0.9/0.7
France	--	-0.4 ---	0.5/0.4

- Consumer confidence remains weak, with no clear trend upward, despite a more stable inflation rate combined with solid labour markets and still high nominal wage increases.
- More fiscal stimulus, tax reliefs and higher minimum wages should support German spending this year.
- In the near term, the Iran war and inflation fear has the potential to hamper spending once again.

Consumers are still cautious

Index, 2020 = 100



Source: German Federal Statistical Office (Statistisches Bundesamt), French National Institute of Statistics & Economic Studies (INSEE), Eurostat, Macrobond, SEB

Euro area: HICP, flash estimate (Mar)

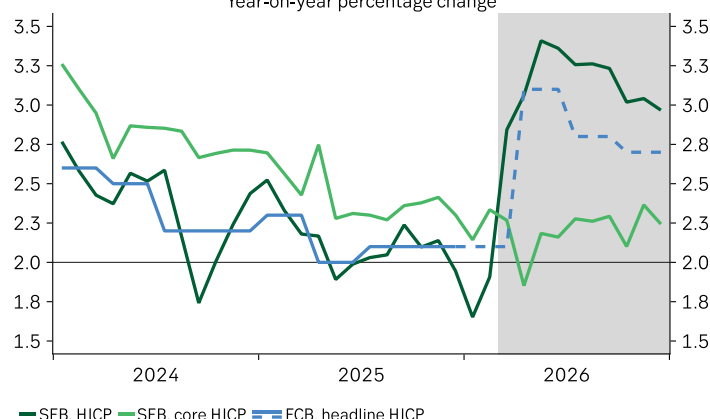
Tuesday 31, 11.00

% y/y	SEB	Cons.	Prev.
HICP	2.8	2.6	1.9
Core	2.3	2.4	2.4

- The inflation environment has shifted due to the war in Iran with sharply higher energy prices. The initial shock to inflation will be a full month of fuel prices turning higher, the impact on home energy is normally delayed and differs massively among economies.
- No spill over will be visible already in March.
- Several governments, next to the EU have started to suggest relief packaged in order to hamper the implications for households. Duration is key, and the longer prices stay elevated, the larger the impact on other goods (food, travel, goods etc).

Initial energy shock to HICP

Year-on-year percentage change



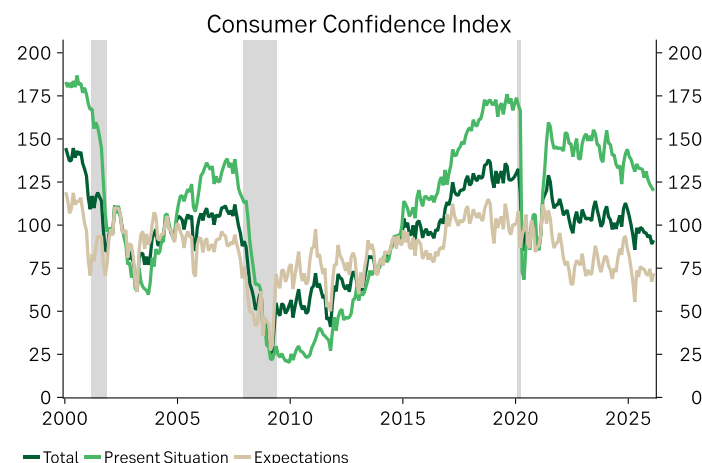
Source: ECB (European Central Bank), Macrobond, SEB

US: Consumer confidence (Mar)

Tuesday 31, 16:00

%	SEB	Cons.	Prev.
Conf. Board consumer conf.	--	88.8	91.2
Present situation	--	--	120.0
Expectations	--	---	72.0

- Consumer confidence will be watched for the impact of the conflict in the Middle East. The cutoff date for the survey varies but usually falls around the middle of the month or slightly thereafter.
- Sharply higher gasoline prices, rising mortgage rates and declining stock markets are likely to start to weigh on confidence, in addition to an already sluggish labour market. New fiscal support (tax rebates) in Q1 is an offsetting factor.
- The present situation index is already at the lowest level since the pandemic but the expectations index, which usually correlates more with spending, is above the lows around Liberation Day in April last year.

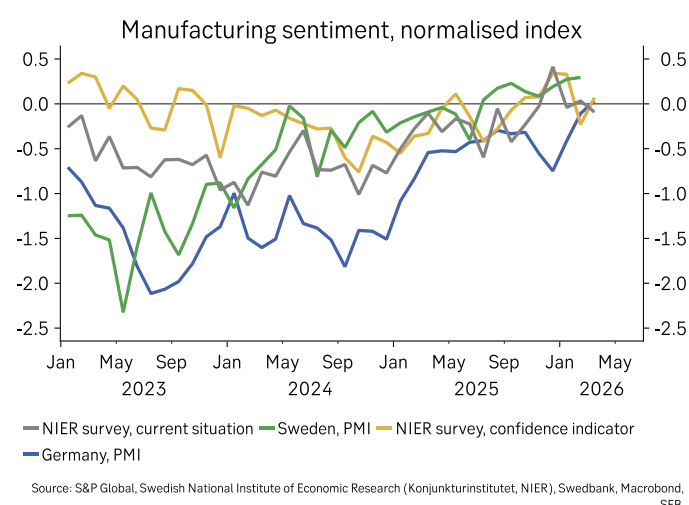


SWE: PMI manufacturing (Mar)

Wednesday 1, 08:30

Index	SEB	Cons.	Prev.
PMI manufacturing	55.0	---	56.1

- Manufacturing PMI has remained firm so far, although manufacturing sentiment according to the NIER survey has declined slightly, despite a partial recovery in March.
- Both German and euro area manufacturing PMI increased slightly in March.
- Market turbulence and sharply higher fuel prices makes us believe that Swedish PMI will decline in March.

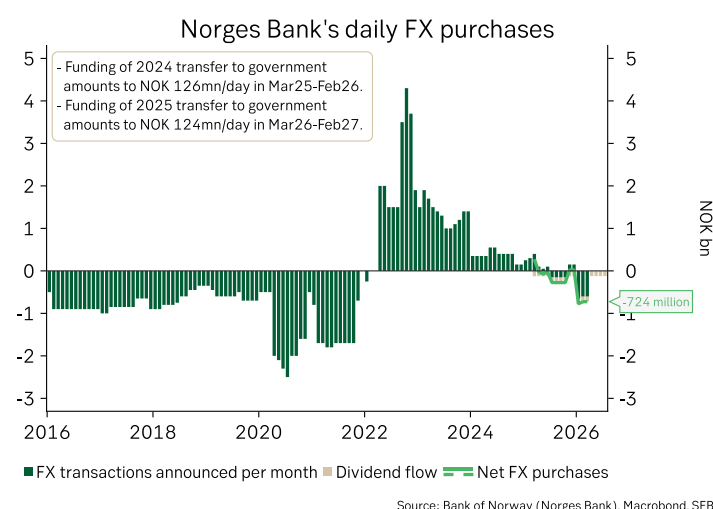


NOR: Norges Bank's FX purchases (Apr)

Wednesday 31, 10:00

NOK mn	SEB	Cons.	Prev.
Daily FX purchases	---	---	-600mn
Daily net FX purchases	---	---	-724mn

- Norges Bank's (NB) daily purchases were relatively small during 2025, implying no meaningful impact on NOK. The 2026 budget has indicated a larger need for NOK purchases in 2026, reflecting lower petroleum tax income and a smaller non-oil budget deficit, as confirmed in Jan-Mar.
- The Middle East war and surge in energy prices will boost petroleum taxes. This implies that oil companies will buy more NOK for tax payments, while NB will reduce NOK purchases equally. The net effect is zero but there will be a timing mismatch as oil companies adjust quickly to higher revenues, while NB's NOK purchases are lagging and dependent on input from the MoF. Hence, we do not expect any large changes to the daily NOK purchases in April.
- In addition, Norges Bank is buying NOK 124mn/day to fund the transfer of profits and interest rates to the government for 2025. This flow is stable in the period Mar26-Feb27. However, the exact number will be given in Norges Bank's annual report (Feb 27).



US: Retail sales (February)

Wednesday 1, 14:30

% mm	SEB	Cons.	Prev.
Retail sales & food services	---	0.4	-0.2
Ex. Auto ex. auto and gas	--- ---	0.3 0.3	0.0 0.3
Retail control*	---	0.3	0.3

* goods excl. autos, gasoline & building materials used as input to GDP.

- Spending slowed markedly in Q4, 2025, after a strong Q3.
- Spending outpaced incomes last year, pushing the savings rate to historically low levels. Rising disposable incomes in January narrowed the gap somewhat. Fiscal support from the OBBBA, with unusually large tax rebates, will support incomes during Q1.
- Rising vehicle sales will support total sales in February after a sharp decline in the previous month.
- Going forward, purchasing power will be hit by sharply higher gasoline prices, while declining stock prices will subtract from wealth. The sluggish labour market is another downside risk.

US: ISM manufacturing (March)

Wednesday 1, 16:00

% mm	SEB	Cons.	Prev.
ISM manufacturing	52.0	52.3	52.4
Prices Paid	---	---	70.5
New orders Employment	---	--- ---	55.8 48.8

- Sentiment indicators will be watched for the impact of the conflict in the Middle East.
- Manufacturing PMI edged higher in March. Subindices showed signs of increased supply problems, with longer delivery times (this is normally interpreted as a sign of increased activity and therefore contributes positively to the main index). PMI price pressures increased, though input prices are at higher levels than selling prices.
- We expect ISM to remain at somewhat expansionary levels in February but with risks of a sharp increase in prices from an already elevated level. ISM prices measure input prices and tend to be sensitive to changes in commodity prices.

US: Nonfarm payrolls (March)

Friday 3, 14:30

- Employment has been volatile in the beginning of the year, partly due to weather conditions and strikes. The underlying trend remains weak. Private employment increased by 34k on average during the past 6-months and total employment declined by 1k (after a large drop for federal workers in October).
- Unemployment increased slightly in February but is unchanged over the past six months and at the upper end of Fed members' view of the longer run (3.8-4.5).
- Indicators suggest a continued sluggish labour market in March. Data from the more comprehensive Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages suggest that official payrolls have continued to overstate employment growth. According to Fed chair Powell job creation in the private sector is near-zero when adjusting for statistical overcounting.
- Higher cost pressures and increased uncertainty due to the conflict in the Middle East is a downside risk going forward.

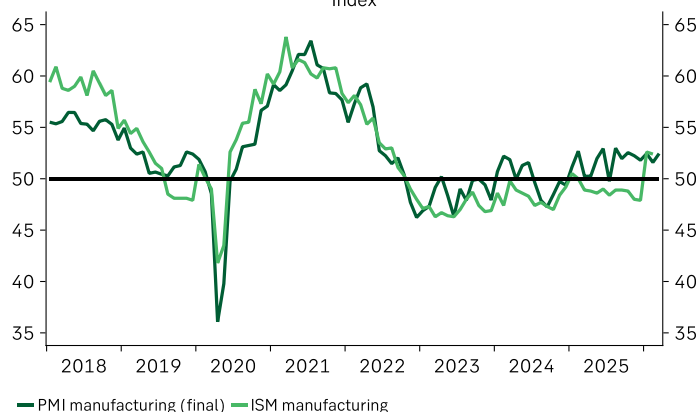
US: Retail sales and consumer confidence

Index and year-on-year percent change



Manufacturing sentiment surveys, ISM vs PMI

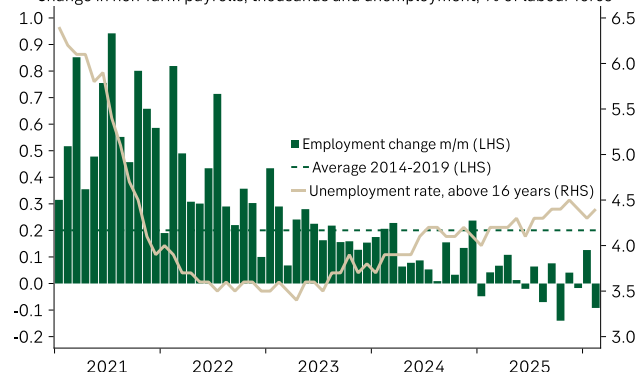
Index



	SEB	Cons.*	Prev.
Total non-farm payrolls chg	40k	50k	-92k
Private manufacturing	--- ---	55k ---	-86k -12k
Unemployment underempl. U6	4.4% ---	4.4% ---	4.4% 7.9%
Hourly wage growth, mm/yy	0.3 / 3.6	0.3 / 3.8	0.4/3.8
Average weekly hours	---	34.3	34.3
Participation rate	---	---	62.0%

US: Employment growth and unemployment

Change in non-farm payrolls, thousands and unemployment, % of labour force



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